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Baba of Karo, a woman of the Muslim Hausa

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There are other relatives whose names we never use: the husband's 'mothers' are called 'Mother of . . .' one of their other children. You must not utter your husband's name, either. Your husband's father is 'Maigida'—'Master of the house'—unless the marriage is between kin, when he is already your father, so you go on calling him 'Baba', 'Father'. Your husband's elder brothers and their wives you call 'Yaya', his elder sister and her husband are 'Yaya' too, like your own elder brothers and sisters. But you joke with his younger brother, and you joke with all your husband's joking relations—his grandparents and cross-cousins. Your husband's mother will say 'Daughter there, do so-and-so', you will reply 'Yes, Mother of Mairo', or 'Yes, Mother of Abubakar'. If she has no other child besides your husband, so there is no name you can use, you may say 'Mother'. You may sit and talk with her. My first husband's mother, Duma's mother, was my father's sister, so I just kept on calling her *Goggo*, father's sister. You don't chat with your husband's father, you just kneel down and greet him.

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Two years after the child's birth, one of the child's grandmothers, usually his father's mother who often lives in the same compound, comes at dawn and knocks on the mother's hut door; she goes in and picks up the child and takes him or her off to her own hut. The child's mother runs off to her own mother's home. In the morning the child bursts out crying, he cries bitterly. Then his grandfather, the father of his father, writes a text on his board and washes off the ink and gives the child the ink of the text to drink, (2) then the womenfolk make gruel and he drinks it. He keeps running to his mother's hut, but he doesn't see her there and he bursts out crying. After three or four days he forgets about the breast. His grandmother has him in her hut and she looks after him. After fourteen days the mother's kinsfolk collect 'dowry' for her at

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their compound, basketfuls of rice, millet, guineacorn, salt, bean-cakes, locust-bean cakes, and her kinswomen bring her to her husband's home. When she arrives everyone says 'Allah give us the bird on the back!', 'Allah give us all health!' Everyone comes to rejoice, the mother dips in to the food they have brought and gives everyone a little, both the people of the compound and any visitors who may come. When her child sees her he rushes to her and she pushes him away and says 'Go on, run off to your own hut!', his grandmother picks him up and comforts him, then he comes back to his mother, and the grandmother carries him off to her own hut. Here  146 is the father's mother's hut, here is the child's mother's hut, quite close to one another. Some children put up with it and stay in their grandmother's hut, some don't and come back to their mother's hut and stay there. Sometimes the child is adopted into another compound, a father's sister or a mother's sister, or one of the grandparents, adopt him. The child's own parents give him to her and she carries him on her back. The kinsfolk of the child's father usually take the first child, and the kinsfolk of the mother take the second. Sometimes the third child is also adopted, but the rest usually stay in their mother's hut. It is we Habe who do that, we give our child as a gift to someone to carry on their back. Fulani won't give him to anyone. Fulani won't give their child to a brother, they don't want their laughter taken to another compound. They laugh and are happy with the child, they won't let him go to another house. If they marry a Habe woman perhaps they will give away a child, but they wouldn't do so on their own. Even if the mother dies, they leave the children in her hut and the father looks after them.

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